

Bordwell and Thompson's definition of story

The story is the chain of events in chronological order.

But as we've seen, that story may be presented in various ways. If we use flashbacks instead of linear time, or if we decide to organize events around one character rather than another, or if we make other choices about presentation, we will be **creating a different plot**.

As we've just seen, the same story can be presented in different ways—rendered as different plots—and each variant is likely to have different effects on the audience.

For spectators:

Story includes not only the on-screen events depicted by the filmmaker, but also the “inferred” or “suggested” events that we might not actually see.

A plot is generally understood to mean events as they happen on screen.

1. Linear: time moves in a straight line from beginning to middle to end
2. Non-Linear: time is presented in a disjointed way – for example the director might use “flashback” or “flashforward” to show the audience past or future events

Story = presumed and inferred events + explicitly presented events

Plot = explicitly presented events + added non-diegetic elements

For instance. moody music, credits, intertitles, voice over are elements of **plot NOT story**

We can consider a *narrative* to be *a chain of events linked by cause and effect and occurring in time and space.*

1. Typically, a narrative begins with one situation;
2. a series of changes occurs according to a pattern of cause and effect;
3. finally, a new situation arises that brings about the end of the narrative.

Our engagement with the story depends on our understanding of *the pattern of change and stability, cause and effect, time and space.*

We make sense of a narrative, then, by identifying its events and linking them by cause and effect, time, and space.

Partly because of our filmmaking decisions

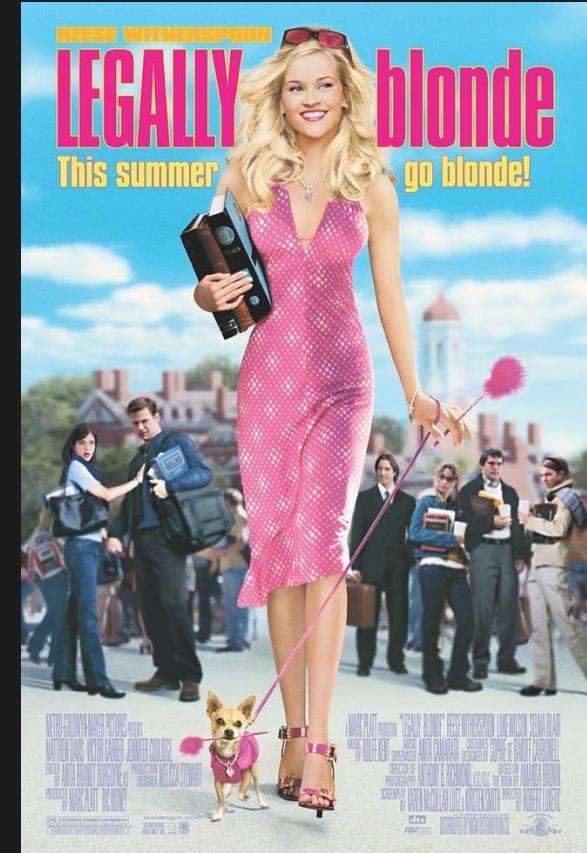
Partly because we need to consider our spectator's reaction to the narrative structure.



"I'll show you how valuable Elle Woods can be!"

Montage, compressing time.

So, story duration, plot duration, screen duration

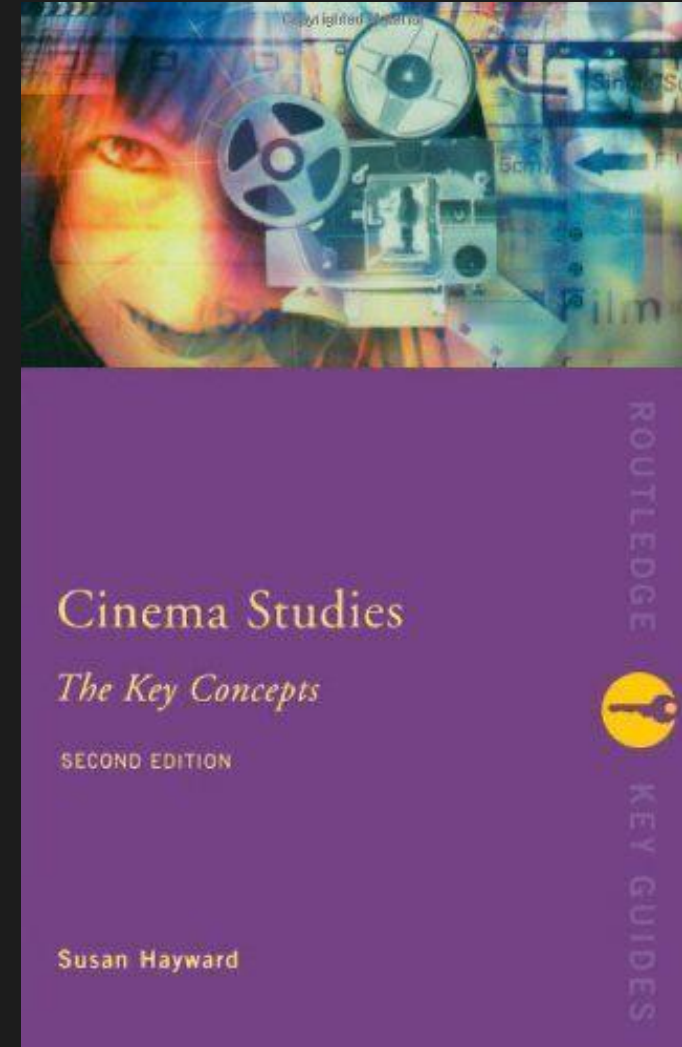


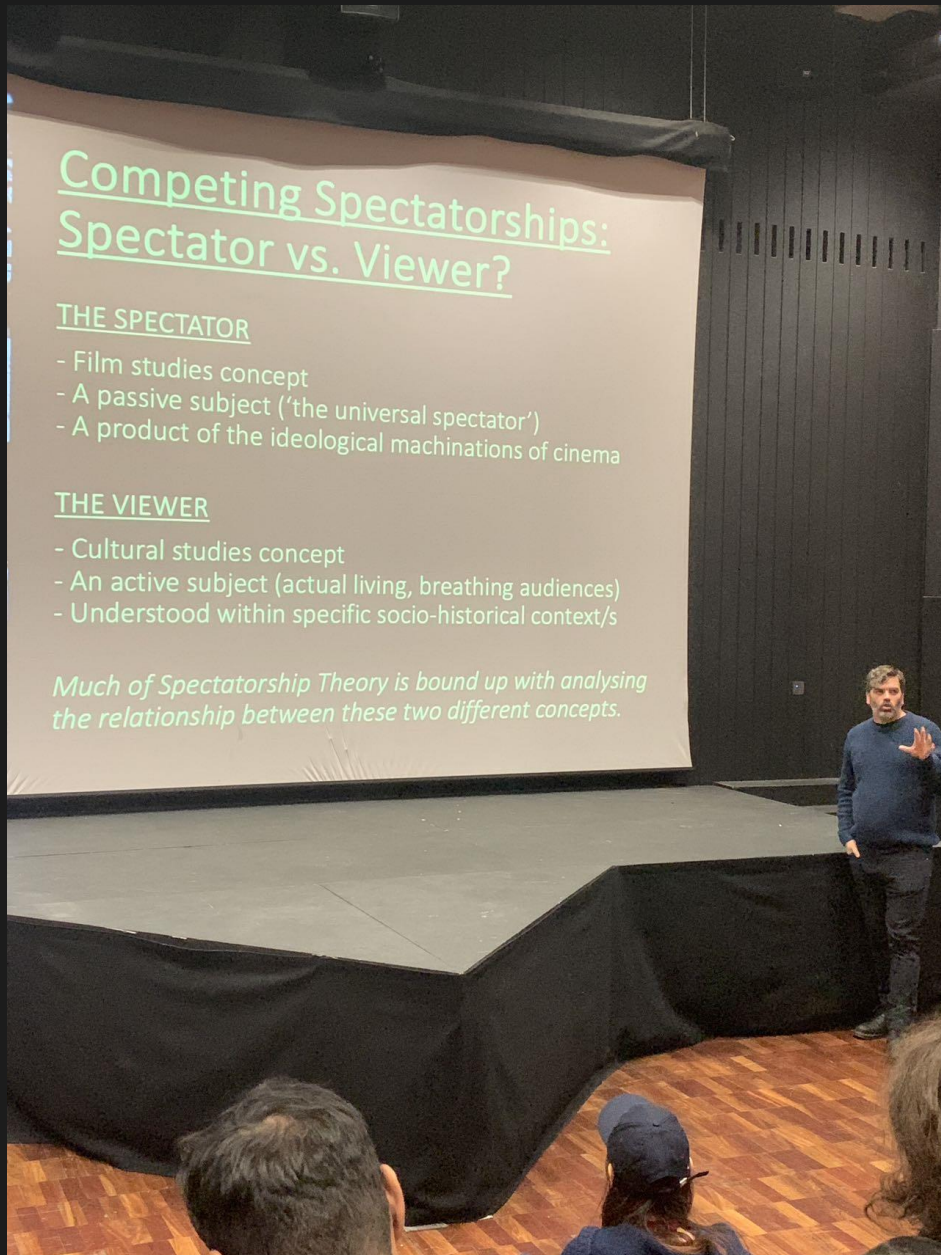
Narrative involves the recounting of real or fictitious events.

Narrative cinema's function is storytelling not description, which is, supposedly, a part function of the documentary.

Narrative refers to the strategies, codes and conventions (including mise-en-scène and lighting) employed to organize a story.

Primarily, narrative cinema is one that uses these strategies as a means of reproducing the 'real' world, one which the spectator can either identify with or consider to be within the realms of possibility.





Spectator, viewer, audience, movie-goers, cinephiles

It is no coincidence that at this historical juncture spectatorship has become a key issue in scholarly debates, especially since the mid-1970s. The shift of focus from the filmic object and its structures to the relations between films and viewers, between cinema and spectator, was a prime motor in the development of a particular direction in film theory, derived from linguistically informed paradigms of semiotics and psychoanalysis. In the writings of Christian Metz, Jean-Louis Baudry, and others, in the pages of the British journal *Screen*, the spectator was conceptualized under the poststructuralist category of the subject (as elaborated by Lacan and Althusser) and corresponding notions of ideology.

The Inclusiveness of “Mise-en-scene”

Week 4



Dr Niles Qi Li
Assistant Professor in Film Studies

- Copy Rights Reserved. Dr Niles Qi Li
- No recording + No digital circulation of PPT, please.

Understanding the role of mise-en-scene

A scene is a very small part of a movie that is composed of several **shots**.

A sequence is a comparatively larger part of the movie that is made up of several scenes.

Many sequences make up a complete **film**.

Bordwell writes: “We look at two techniques governing the shot, mise-en-scene and cinematography. Then we consider the technique that relates shot to shot, editing. Then we consider the role that sound plays in relation to film images. “

Four components of film style or “what can be cinematic”

1. **Mise-en-scene:** involves anything appears on screen, which includes sets, props, costumes, actors and even light
2. **Cinematography:** all technical factors
3. **Editing:** a process of selecting already-filmed materials then put them together
4. **Sound:** somethings that plays a part in every stage process

Three questions confront the filmmaker:

1. What to shoot?
2. How to shoot it?
3. How to present the shot?

The domain of the first two questions is mise-en-scene and cinematography, that of the last, *montage/editing*.

▼ PART THREE • Film Style

> CHAPTER 4 The Shot: Mise-en-Scene

> CHAPTER 5 The Shot: Cinematography

> CHAPTER 6 The Relation of Shot to Shot: Editing

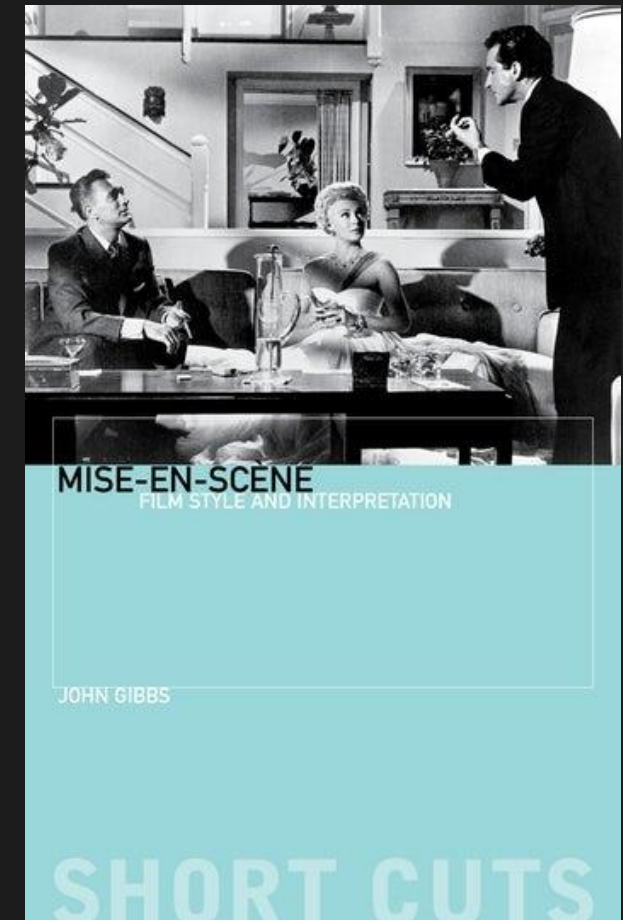
> CHAPTER 7 Sound in the Cinema

> CHAPTER 8 Summary: Style and Film Form

Mise-en-scene: definitions

(as a mechanic system, not explanative)

For the student of film, a useful definition of “mise-en-scene” might be: ‘the contents of the frame and the way that they are organised.’



A workable definition of “mise-en-scene”

In theatre, the contents of the stage and their arrangement; in cinema, the contents of the film frame, including elements of **the profilmic event** such as performers, settings, costumes, and props ,acting and performance. In French, mise-en-scène literally means “the action of putting onto the stage.” The term originated in stage drama, where it refers to the way actors and scenery props are arranged; as its usage expanded into other narrative arts, its meaning shifted.

Mise-en-scene also refers more broadly to what the viewer actually sees on the screen (lighting, colour, composition, and iconographic aspects of the” “cinematic image, for example); and also to the relationship between onscreen and offscreen space created **by the framing of the image** and **by camera movement**.

A key component of film style, mise-en-scene produces meaning, if only at a very basic level, by providing visual information about the world of a film’s narrative, say. In some films, however, mise-en-scene can be a site of extraordinarily complex and subtle meanings, as in the Hollywood films of Douglas Sirk, for example, in which mise-en-scene often provides ironic commentary on the characters and the worlds they inhabit. In film studies, mise-en-scene is an indispensable concept in understanding film style and in making critical distinctions between films of different genres, historical periods, and national provenances; it can also be a key concept in studies of *authorship in film. (**for instance, sitcom, German Expressionist Cinema**)

Then, we need to understand the history of the concept:

A French theatrical term that means “put into place” or “staging an action.”

Originally a theatre term meaning ‘staging’, it crossed over to signify the film production practices involved in the framing of shots.

Thus, first it connotes setting, costume and lighting, second, movement *within* the frame.

It became endowed with a more specific meaning by the *Cahiers du cinéma* group (established in 1951) who used it to justify their appellation of certain American film-makers as auteurs.

Given that these directors were working under the aegis of Hollywood they had no control over the script but they could stage their shots and so be deemed to have a discernible style. *Mise-en-scène* is the expressive tool at the film-maker’s disposal which a critic can read to determine the specificity of the cinematographic work. That is, the critic can identify the particular style of a specific film-maker and thereby point to it as an authorial sign.



Let's turn to a similar term:

“Framing”

The arrangement and composition of elements in a film frame, i.e. the entire rectangular area of a film image as projected or as visible on the screen.

In the Hollywood studio era shot sizes were standardized to ensure *continuity for *editing, and these standards still dominate framing today. To this extent framing for film is pragmatic: it follows a set of rules which can be seen in the vocabulary of **shot size** (for instance, **LS, ECU, MCU**). When the continuity system is followed strictly, all shot sizes are framed consistently, and the precise framing of the actor is paramount.

A standard closeup, for example, crops just below the shoulders and puts the eyes of the actor along an imaginary line that cuts across the top third of the screen horizontally: this placing of the eyes provides for a small amount of space above the actor's head. To enhance consistency of framing, *lighting and *focus visually isolate the actor from the background, ensuring his or her dominance in the image. Even performance is subsidiary to framing: screen actors stay relatively still, except as their role requires them to move—in which case in order to ensure correct framing they keep in position by following marks on the floor.”

Components of Mise-en-scene :

(in DB's textbook: p.115

setting, costume and make-up, lighting, staging: movement and performance)



setting

acting

decor

hairstyle

makeup

costumes

props

lighting



setting

Setting

Part of the total concept of mise-en-scène. The setting is literally the location where the action takes place, and it can be artificially constructed (as **in studio sets**) or natural (what is also termed **location shooting**).

Certain film movements are readily associated with a type of setting:

- the distorted settings of German expressionist films,
- the dimly lit rainwashed streets and empty cold interiors in films noir.
- the natural settings of Italy's cities and countryside in Italian neo-realism films.



Live-action films: Mise-en-scène in live-action films relies on physical sets, real locations, and practical props. The director, production designer, and cinematographer collaborate to design and arrange these elements within the frame.

But in animated films, the worlds are constructed. In animation, every element of the mise-en-scène is created from scratch, either by hand (traditional animation) or digitally (CGI). This allows for complete control over the visual world, including fantastical or impossible elements.



Filmmakers can use mise-en-scene to achieve realism, giving settings an authentic look or letting actors perform as naturally as possible.

Sure, but what else?

“worldhood” is another term, we have to compare “setting” with.

- While "setting" refers to the physical and temporal location of a story, "worldhood" encompasses the broader, more holistic experience of the filmic world.
- Worldhood includes the emotional, psychological, and symbolic layers that make the world feel alive and meaningful to the viewer.



Mise-en-scene and sitcoms (situation comedy)



Melodrama

All That Heaven Allows: The décor reflects Cary's (Jane Wyman) entrapment within the middle-class home

"The melodrama is iconographically fixed by the claustrophobic atmosphere of the bourgeois home and/or the small-town setting, its emotional pattern is that of panic and latent hysteria, reinforced stylistically by a complex handling of space in interiors (Sirk, Ray and Losey particularly excel in this) to the point where the world seems totally predetermined and pervaded by 'meaning' and inter- pretable signs. " (Christine Gledhill, *Home is Where the Heart Is*, p.62)



A modern melodrama is a dramatic work in which plot, typically sensationalized for a strong emotional appeal, takes precedence over detailed characterization. Melodrama is "an exaggerated version of drama".



Brokeback Mountain (2005). In the expansive mountains and plains of the American West, two cowboys explore new sexual intimacies, as the film confounds expectations associated with setting.

Mise-en-scène as an *external condition*

indicates surfaces, objects, and exteriors that define the material possibilities in a place or space.

The mise-en-scène may be a magical space full of active objects, or it may be a barren landscape with no borders.

We can argue:

Render the same-sex desire as a part of "natural" setting.

The mise-en-scene couples queer intimacy with nature.

The vast landscape and the iconic costume are not simply indicative of the genre "Western Movies".



1. The Naturalistic Tradition

Naturalism is one of the most effective—and most misleading—ways to approach mise-en-scène. If mise-en-scène is about the arrangement of space and the objects in it, as we have suggested, then naturalism in the mise-en-scène means that how a place looks is the way it is supposed to look.

We can, in fact, pinpoint several more precise characteristics of a naturalistic mise-en-scène:

- The world and its objects follow assumed laws of nature and society.
- The elements of the mise-en-scène have a consistently logical or homogeneous relation to each other.
- The mise-en-scène and the characters mutually define each other, although the
- mise-en-scène may be unresponsive to the needs and desires of the characters.

Naturalism VS. Realism

“In film studies, naturalism is often taken to be synonymous with realism; however, where a distinction is made, naturalism is understood as that which merely reproduces external appearances, while realism attempts to go beyond or beneath the surface to describe the generative forces that give reality its particular appearance.

2. The Theatrical Tradition

In contrast, theatrical mise-en-scène creates fantastical environments that display and even exult in their artificial and constructed nature.

Films in this tradition define themselves in one or more of these terms:

- Elements of the mise-en-scène tend to violate or bend the laws of nature or society.
- Dramatic inconsistencies appear within one or between two or more settings.
- The mise-en-scène takes on an independent life that requires confrontations or creative negotiations between the props and sets and the characters.

THE COOK, THE THIEF, HIS WIFE & HER LOVER



© picture-alliance/ZB/T. Schulze

NIGHTWATCHING



British film director

Peter Greenaway's cinematic work

Lighting

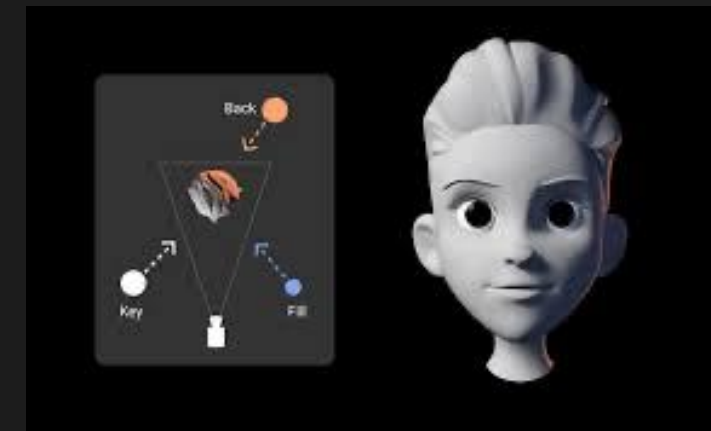
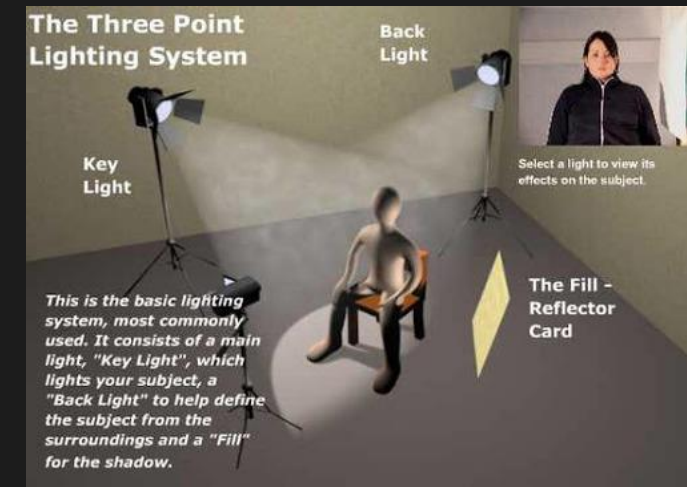
Lighting

In the earliest cinema only natural lighting was used, most of the shooting was done in exteriors or in studios that had glass roofs or roofs that could open to the sunlight. As narratives became more complex (early 1900s) and as increased demand for products meant working to tight shooting schedules, clearly using ordinary sunlight was not satisfactory enough since it was not easily controllable.



Soft lighting and hard lighting

Lighting in animation starts with three key components: key light, fill light, and backlight (together referred to as three-point lighting.) The key light is the primary light source, often setting the scene's initial mood. A harsh key light can cast stark shadows, perfect for creating a mood of suspense or drama. Conversely, a softer key light can produce a gentle and inviting atmosphere.





Colour



Acting and Performance

Facial expression, body movement

Individualize acting VS stylized acting

- individualized: create a broad type character or create a unique character that contains individual psychology
- - Stylized acting: (depends on degree of stylization)
- **naturalistic/understated** performance VS **exaggerated** performance

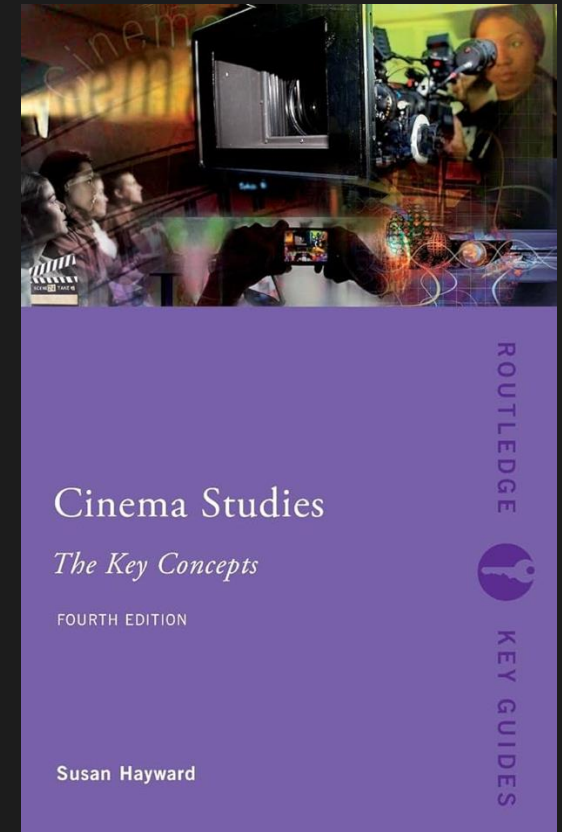
Stereotype and typecasting

Different terminology: Acting , or Performance?

Let's have a look at Susan Hayward's definition:

“The work of creating a dramatic character by a professional or amateur performer. The term acting is most often used in relation to narrative cinema, where the construction of character is central, with the term performance used to describe both the work of acting and more broadly the role of the body in the cinema, including in relation to non-narrative film.

Actors construct characters through their bodies (posture, gesture, and movement augmented by costume, makeup, hairstyle, etc.) and voices (tone, accent, delivery, and so on). Action, reaction, and interaction between actors are also fundamental elements of any performance.”

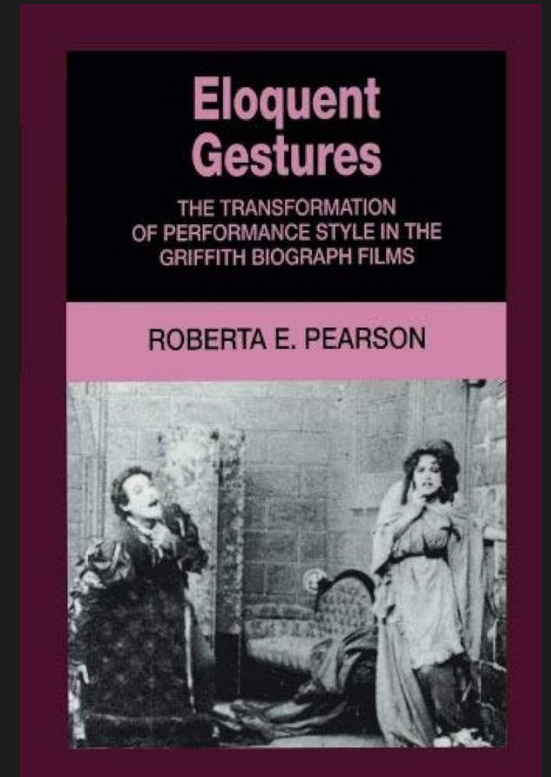


Film historian Roberta Pearson has charted a move in acting styles from a 'histrionic' style (1907–12) to a 'verisimilar' style (1912–48).

In the former, the actor represents a character's emotions through large gestures: this style of acting (also referred to as pictorial acting) had its roots in a western European theatrical tradition (where large theatre spaces required gestures to be broad) and was also a way of conveying meaning in films when spoken dialogue was not available (particularly in EARLY CINEMA). In contrast, the verisimilar code was judged to be more 'realistic' because it was modelled on everyday behaviour and was therefore not so clearly conventionalized (*verisimilar acting is sometimes called invisible acting*)."

What is 'verisimilar and verisimilitude'?"

"The appearance of being true or real; believability. Verisimilitude is a property that a film is said to display if it convincingly depicts a world that is congruent with the audience's expectations about what that world is like. The term denotes the particular form of realism associated with *classical Hollywood cinema: "



applied to all types of theatrical performance. As a result, the chapters in part 1 are designed to treat systematically the following concerns:

(1) A framing or cuing process that establishes a boundary between performers and audience, producing an elementary theatrical event. The boundary can be more or less ambiguous, eliciting different sorts of interaction between two social groups.

(2) A set of rhetorical conventions, controlling the ostensiveness of the players, their relative positions within the performing space, and their mode of address to the audience.

4 Introduction

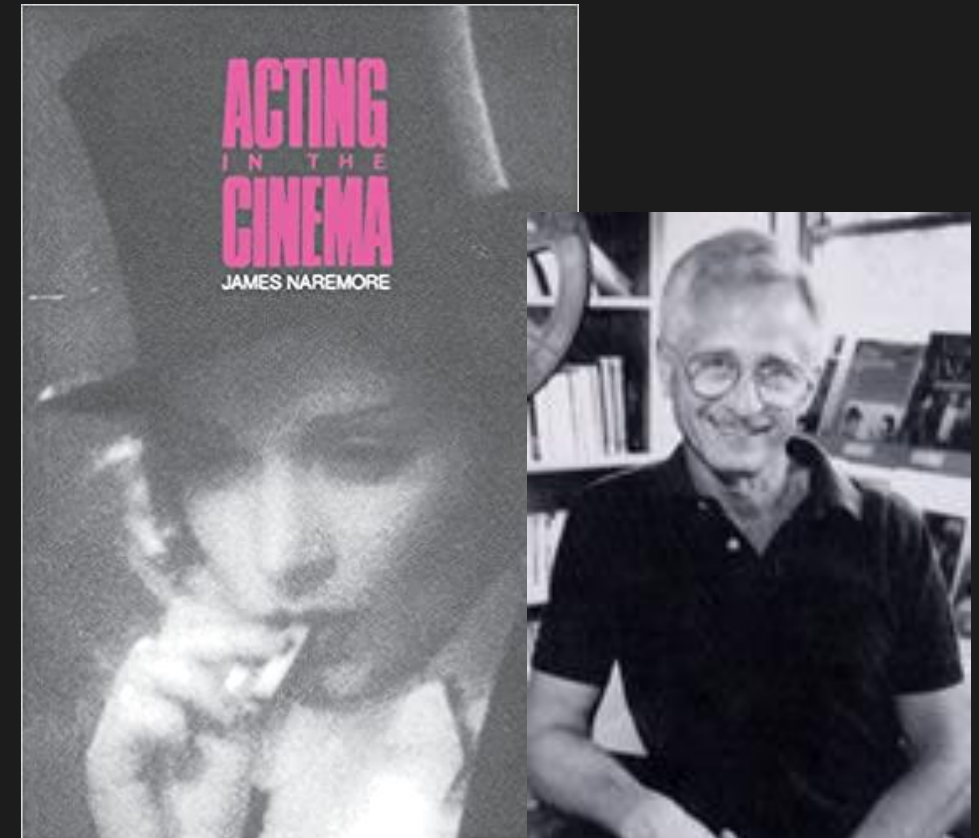
(3) A series of expressive techniques governing such matters as posture, gesture, and voice, and regulating the entire body as an index of gender, age, ethnicity, and social class.

(4) A logic of coherence, enabling the players to seem more or less in step with changes in the story, more or less in character, and more or less “true to themselves.”

(5) A *mise-en-scène*, shaping the performance to a greater or lesser degree by clothing, makeup, and a variety of inanimate objects with which the actor comes into direct contact.

I might have termed this structure the “five codes” of performance, inventing names for each item in the list: the boundary code, the rhetorical code, the expressive code, the harmonic code, and the anthropomorphic code. I have preferred, however, to repress jargon and not pursue the analogy

The dilemma for acting and performance



James Naremore

The arrangement and movement of actors in relation to each other within the physical space of a mise-en-scène is called **blocking**.

1. *Social blocking* describes the arrangement of characters to accentuate relations among them.
2. *Graphic blocking* arranges characters or groups according to visual patterns to portray spatial harmony, tension, or some other visual atmosphere



2.22 *Little Women* (1994). Blocking the family tightly around the father as a subtle expression of a symbolic social structure.



2.23 *Metropolis* (1927). Masses of workers move in linear formation through a futuristic setting in which individuality itself is in doubt.



Little Women is set during the American Civil War. The coming-of-age story **narrates** the lives of the four March sisters on their journey to womanhood. When their father was deployed to war, the girls and their mother were left to their own devices.



Metropolis is a 1927 German expressionist science-fiction silent film directed by Fritz Lang

Depth cues and space

(all the aspects of the mise-en-scene)

Looking at a film image as a two-dimensional picture helps us appreciate the artistry of filmmakers, but it requires some effort. We find it easier to immediately see the shapes on the screen as presenting a three-dimensional area, like the spaces we live in. The elements of the image that create this impression are called depth cues.

In cinema, depth cues are provided by lighting, setting, costumes, staging, etc— all the aspects of the mise-en-scene.

By seeing depth cues, we indirectly gain the ability to understand the narrative elements of a scene, and in turn, what it may mean to us as a whole.

Humans have **eight depth cues** that are used by the brain to estimate the relative distance of the objects in every scene we look at. These are focus, perspective, occlusion, light and shading, colour intensity and contrast, relative movement, vergence and stereopsis.

Depth cues also pick out **planes within the image**. Planes are the layers of space occupied by persons or objects. Planes are described according to how close to or far away from the camera they are: **foreground, middle ground, background**.

So, what is in the foreground? What are the background objects? Are they clear or blurred?



Case 1:

Citizen Kane
(Orsen Welles, 1941)

A close-up, black and white photograph of a handwritten note in cursive script. The text is partially visible, showing the words "I first enca". The ink is dark on a light-colored, slightly textured paper. The handwriting is fluid and characteristic of the early 20th century.

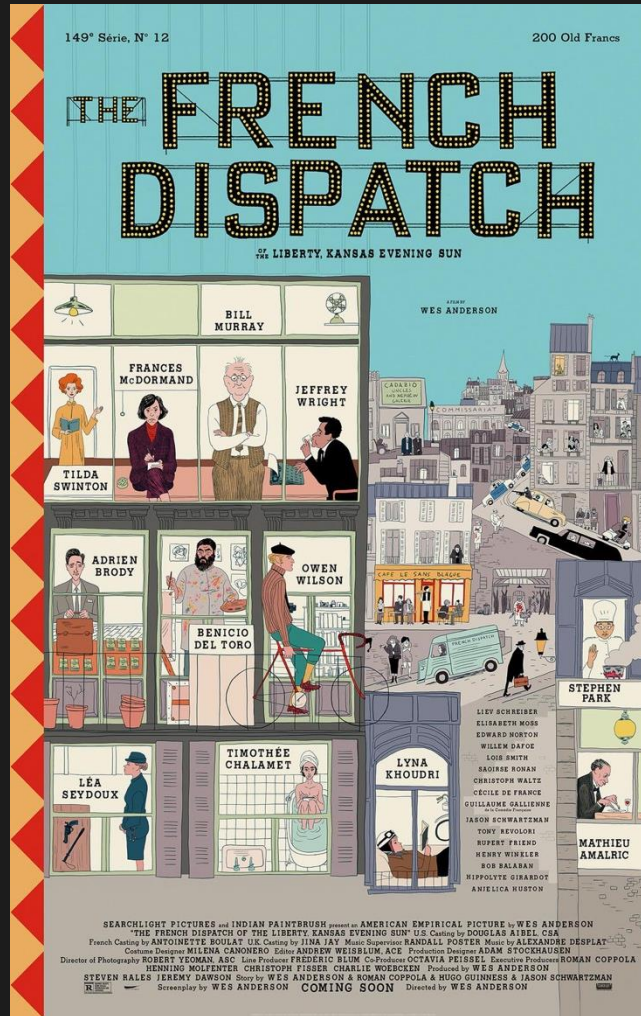
positioning of characters

certain lighting

shot techniques.



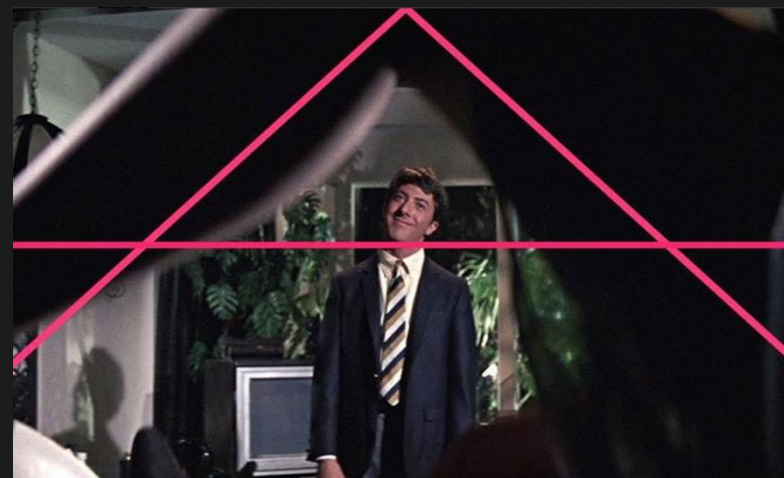
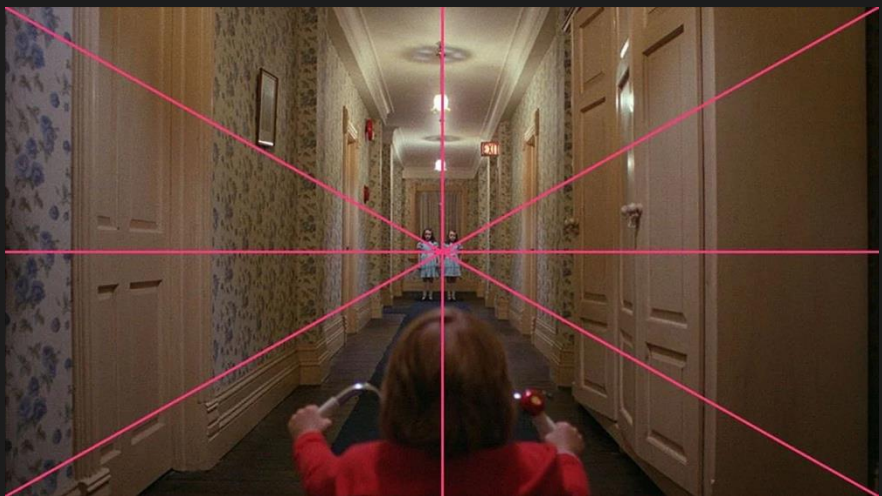
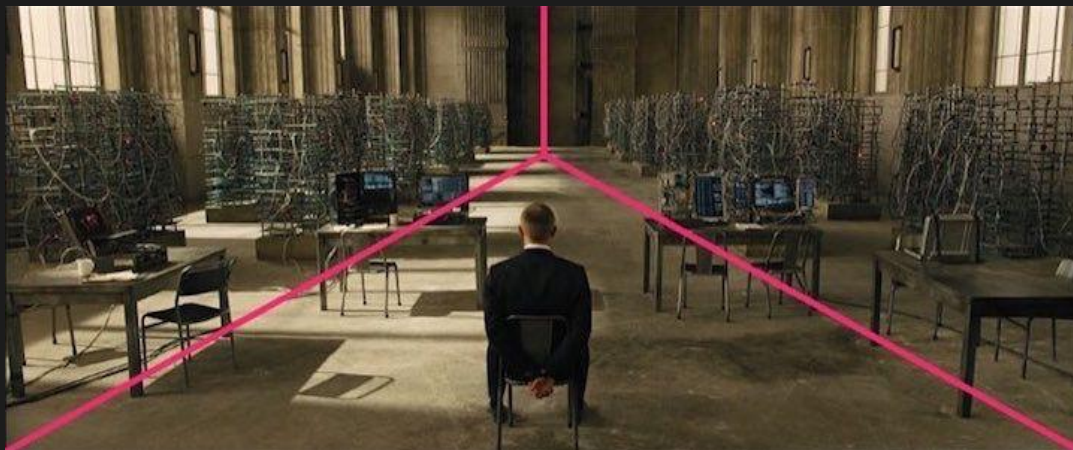
Case 2: the movement within the frame



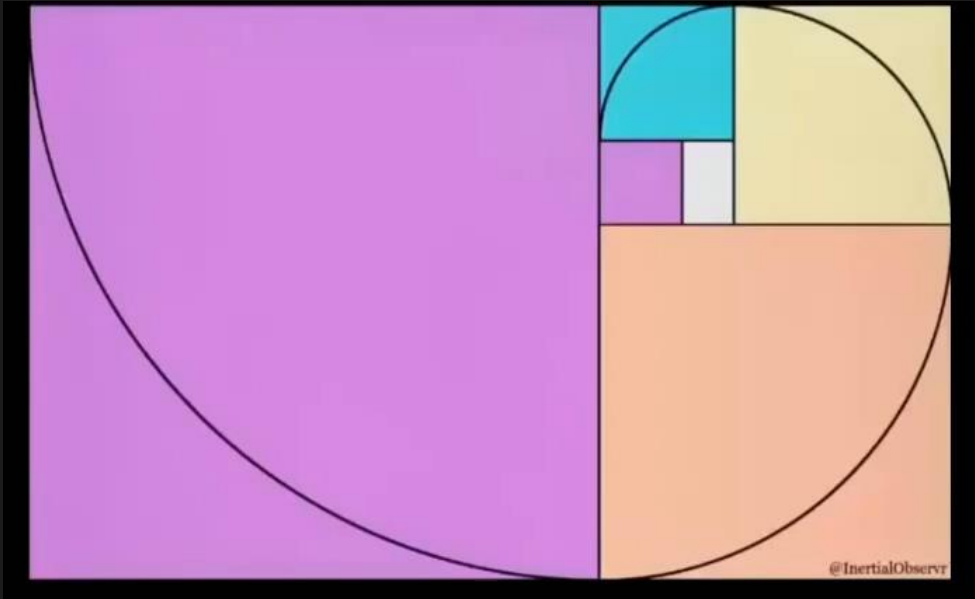
A love letter to journalists set in an outpost of an American newspaper in a fictional twentieth century French city that brings to life a collection of stories published in "The French Dispatch Magazine".

A very Wes Anderson Movie





Case 2



The golden ratio, also known as the golden number, golden proportion, or the divine proportion, is a ratio between two numbers that equals approximately 1.618.



Case 3: mise-en-scene and the narrative function

After a series of assassinations in Nanking, a Japanese spy master gathers a group of suspects in a mansion, then a tense cat-and-mouse game erupts as the Chinese agent tries to keep his or her identity a secret.

The Message (Chen Kuo-fu and Qunshu Gao, 2009)

Espionage & war film



In live-action films, changes to the mise-en-scène often require physical adjustments (e.g., rearranging props, resetting lights). In contrast, every detail of the mise-en-scène in animated films should be meticulously planned and executed. Animators can adjust lighting, textures, and compositions with precision, often using software tools.